

Reflecting on an Important Decision and a Significant Problem

This reflection examines two experiences from my life: my decision to seek an adult assessment for autism and ADHD, and my difficulties taking breaks before becoming overloaded. Theories of decision making and problem solving provided new insights into how both were shaped by emotion, assumptions, habits, and framing.

An Important Decision

For many years, I had a strong need for structure and predictability and experienced sensory and social overload, intense concentration, and difficulties regulating attention and energy. I mainly understood these as aspects of my personality or weaknesses I should manage better. However, autism and ADHD were already part of my life through my family and work with neurodivergent people, and I gradually recognised similar patterns in myself. Although I wondered whether an assessment might offer an explanation, I questioned whether my experiences were significant enough and feared not being believed or having my identity narrowed by a diagnosis. As these patterns increasingly made sense across different areas of my life, my need for clarity eventually outweighed my uncertainty, and I requested an assessment, which led to both diagnoses. Although the decision developed over time, I mistook prolonged reflection for systematic reasoning. I had not clearly separated whether autism and ADHD might explain my experiences from the practical question of whether there was enough reason to seek assessment without certainty about the explanation.

Halpern and Dunn's (2023) approach to decision making helps show what was missing, as it emphasises defining the decision, generating alternatives, evaluating evidence, and reviewing the outcome. I had viewed my options as either requesting a full assessment or doing nothing, although I could also have arranged an initial consultation, recorded my experiences over time, or sought

support without immediately pursuing diagnosis. These alternatives might have made the decision feel less final and helped distinguish lifelong patterns from difficulties linked mainly to stress.

The next issue was how I weighed possible outcomes, which can be examined through von Neumann and Morgenstern's (1944) Expected Utility Theory. The theory compares options by combining the likelihood of each outcome with its personal value or cost. To apply it, I could have rated assessment as having a 0.70 probability of providing useful clarity with a utility of +8, and a 0.30 probability of limited clarity or emotional difficulty with a utility of -4. Its expected utility would therefore be +4.4. Delaying assessment might have had a 0.30 probability of providing temporary relief with a utility of +3 and a 0.70 probability of continued confusion with a utility of -6, producing a lower expected utility of -3.3 (see Table 1). These figures would have been subjective rather than factual, but the comparison could still have exposed how strongly I weighted the immediate costs of assessment while underestimating the cost of continued uncertainty.

Table 1. *Illustrative application of Expected Utility Theory using subjective probabilities and utilities.*

Option	Outcome	Probability	Utility	Expected Utility
Assessment	Useful clarity	0.70	+8	+4.4
	Limited clarity / emotional difficulty	0.30	-4	
Delay assessment	Temporary relief	0.30	+3	-3.3
	Continued confusion	0.70	-6	

This imbalance also reflected how I reacted to possible losses. Kahneman and Tversky's (1979) Prospect Theory suggests that outcomes are judged as gains or losses relative to a reference point, with losses often having a stronger psychological effect than equivalent gains. This helps

explain why I gave so much weight to dismissal, an unwanted label, or seeing myself only through diagnostic categories, while giving less attention to the possible gain in self-understanding. At the same time, considering the consequences of delay would also have shown that uncertainty was not neutral.

I also needed to examine how I interpreted evidence through Tenenbaum et al.'s (2011) Bayesian models, in which prior beliefs are updated as evidence accumulates. I would initially have treated autism, ADHD, anxiety, prolonged stress, and their overlap as competing explanations. Family diagnoses, lifelong patterns, and difficulties across settings would have increased the plausibility of a neurodevelopmental explanation, whereas evidence that the difficulties appeared only during acute stress would have weakened it. Stress and anxiety would still remain relevant because they can coexist with autism and ADHD and intensify similar difficulties. Although reliable probabilities were unavailable, making the updates explicit would have been more transparent than moving gradually towards one explanation.

As I increasingly recognised myself in descriptions of autism and ADHD, confirmation bias may also have influenced the process. Halpern and Dunn (2023) explain that this bias can lead people to give greater weight to supporting evidence, so I may have noticed similarities more readily than differences. A stronger process would have considered what did not fit and whether other explanations accounted for my experiences, treating self-recognition as a reason to seek assessment rather than proof.

Emotion also played a part in this process, as Lerner et al. (2015) show that emotions can influence attention, risk perception, and evaluation. Fear increased the apparent cost of assessment, while hope made confirming descriptions more persuasive. Research on late diagnosis reflects this

tension, as French and Cassidy (2026) found that receiving an autism or ADHD diagnosis later in life could support greater self-understanding while also bringing emotional and identity challenges.

The later diagnoses do not prove that my original reasoning was sound, because knowing the outcome may now make the decision seem more obvious than it was. Halpern and Dunn (2023) describe this as hindsight bias, where an outcome appears more predictable after it has occurred. However, a favourable outcome can still follow an incomplete process, just as careful reasoning can lead to disappointment. For this reason, I would judge the decision by how openly I considered evidence, alternatives, and uncertainty rather than by the outcome alone.

A Significant Problem

In a separate area of my life, receiving the diagnoses gave me a new way to examine why I often failed to take breaks before becoming overloaded. Intense concentration, reduced awareness of time, and difficulty switching activities offered possible explanations, although they did not account for the problem on their own.

The difficulty became especially clear while I was combining online study, work, and personal responsibilities. Online study offered flexibility but few natural stopping points, and I could become absorbed for hours with little awareness of time, hunger, or physical tension. Even when I noticed tiredness, I often continued because stopping felt risky, as I feared losing my train of thought and struggling to restart. My first response was to create increasingly detailed schedules, but these focused on what I wanted to complete rather than how long I could work sustainably. When I fell behind, I removed breaks and continued until my concentration declined and small decisions felt overwhelming. I had therefore defined success as working until everything was finished rather than completing the most important work while remaining able to function afterwards. This was an ill-defined problem because neither the appropriate goal nor the best route towards it was initially clear.

Newell and Simon's (1972) concept of a problem space clarifies how I could have approached this differently. My initial state involved unfinished work, limited time, few stopping cues, and difficulty disengaging, while the goal would have been useful progress without severe overload or prolonged recovery. Reaching that goal was constrained by workload, time pressure, fear of losing my place, and difficulty switching, so possible operators could have included external reminders, brief pauses, writing down the next step, and stopping at natural section boundaries. I could have divided the route into subgoals: responding to the cue, taking the break, and returning without losing direction. Rather than continuing unsystematically, I would have tested a five-minute break after 45 minutes of work and monitored overload and recovery time for one week. These observations would then have shown whether to continue, revise, or stop the strategy.

This approach differs from my original response because it treats sustainable progress as a satisfactory outcome rather than trying to complete everything. It also challenges a mental set, which Halpern and Dunn (2023) describe as continuing to use an approach that worked previously even when it no longer fits. Persistence had often helped me complete difficult tasks, so I treated more effort as the solution whenever I felt pressure. However, this problem required regulation rather than persistence and focusing on the immediate benefit of continuing obscured the later cost.

External cues may therefore be useful because relying on my awareness of time may not be sufficient, particularly as Mette's (2023) review found some evidence of time perception difficulties in adults with ADHD. Hupfeld et al. (2024) similarly describe hyperfocus as intense concentration that may reduce awareness of time and surroundings, while Buckle et al. (2021) found that some autistic adults experienced difficulties stopping or switching and sometimes relied on external interruption. These findings support testing a reminder before overload becomes severe, but autism and ADHD should not be treated as complete explanations, as workload, stress, perfectionism, sleep, and the study environment may also contribute.

The strategy would therefore need to be tested rather than treated as a fixed solution, particularly as Albulescu et al. (2022) found only small benefits of microbreaks for vigour and fatigue, with effectiveness varying according to the task and break length. If a timer disrupted my concentration or made restarting harder, I could instead pause at natural boundaries or adjust the timing. This would not guarantee a better outcome, but it would provide a more deliberate way of learning what works. Most importantly, I would no longer assume that being able to continue meant I should, particularly when the later cost reduced both my wellbeing and the quality of my work.

Conclusion

Seeking assessment helped me understand longstanding patterns, while the problem with breaks showed that understanding alone does not create change. In both cases, I needed to question how I had framed the situation, as I focused on possible losses when considering assessment and treated persistence as the solution to overload. A more systematic approach would not have removed uncertainty, but it would have made the assumptions, emotions, and habits guiding my thinking more visible and easier to test.

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